Alphabet

Google Cloud Next 2026: Key Themes & Expectations; Top Pick, Reiterate Overweight & $395 PT

Overweight

GOOG, GOOG US
Price (17 Apr 26):$339.40
Price Target (Dec-26):$395.00

Overweight

GOOGL, GOOGL US
Price (17 Apr 26):$341.68
Price Target (Dec-26):$395.00

Internet - Large Cap / Mid & Small Cap

Doug Anmuth [AC]
(1-212) 622-6571
douglas.anmuth@jpmorgan.com

Dae K Lee, CFA
(1-415) 315-8500
dae.k.lee@jpmorgan.com

Margaret Hoffman
(1-212) 622-1710
margaret.hoffman@jpmchase.com
J.P. Morgan Securities LLC

Google kicks off an eventful 5 weeks with Google Cloud Next 2026 in Las Vegas April 22–24, 1Q earnings on April 29 (see our preview), Google I/O (May 19-20), & Google Marketing Live (May 20). While Cloud Next has not been a major catalyst for GOOG/L shares in the past, we believe the event carries more weight this year given Google Cloud's increasing importance as the company's 2nd largest business line at ~19% of revenue in 2026 (behind Search at 53%) and the fastest growing, w/revenue accelerating from +48% reported Y/Y in 4Q to JPMe +61% in 1Q, & backlog having surged +160% Y/Y to $240B in 4Q25. On margins, Google Cloud GAAP OI margin expanded +960bps Y/Y to 23.7% in 2025, and we model a further +420bps Y/Y to 27.9% in 2026 as strong top-line growth—driven by accelerating AI workload adoption, agentic consumption, & backlog conversion—should allow Cloud OI margins to continue expanding even as the infrastructure build-out weighs on the cost base. We expect this year's event to highlight the momentum Google Cloud has been building over the past 3 years. **The central question heading in is whether Google can convert AI infrastructure & model investments into durable enterprise adoption, repeatable ROI, and margin-resilient unit economics vs. AWS and Azure, and increasingly Anthropic and OpenAI.** We believe the event will help underscore the importance of Google's heavy capex spending (2026 guide of $175B–$185B & JPMe +25% to $226B in 2027), and we expect to see confirmation that agentic AI is moving from experimental to an operational necessity across customers, evidence that multi-agent workflows expand Google's footprint across data, infrastructure, & security, & signs that Google is generating efficiencies and improving unit economics. **We remain confident Google is well-positioned to deliver on these fronts—GOOG/L is our top pick, and we reiterate our Overweight rating & our $395 Dec '26 PT based on ~29x our '27E GAAP EPS of $13.51.**

- **What we expect at Google Cloud Next 2026.** We expect four key themes: **1) Agentic Cloud** — Google Cloud is evolving from enterprises using AI for individual tasks—summarizing documents, generating code, analyzing data—toward networks of AI agents that can coordinate & complete multi-step workflows together. Once these agents are embedded into daily enterprise operations, Google Cloud usage becomes recurring & much harder for customers to rip out, driving both consumption & retention. **2) Making data easier to use** — Google is pushing to let non-technical users ask questions in plain English across BigQuery, Cloud SQL, & Spanner to get real answers & actions in return. The goal is to own the full loop from question to action & pull more compute & storage spend onto Google's platform, taking share from incumbent data warehouse & analytics providers. **3) AI infrastructure & cost efficiency** — We look for updates on Google's next-gen TPUs (incl. 7th gen Ironwood that entered GA), GPU instances, & broader infrastructure optimizations, now complemented by the $4.75B Intersect acquisition that closed in 1Q, which expands Google's data center & infrastructure capabilities. The key question is whether Google can keep AI pricing competitive while protecting or improving margins through its custom-built chips (TPUs/Axion),

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which give Google a structural cost advantage over most competitors. **4) AI-powered security** — We look for updates to Security Command Center & a new "Agentic Security Operations Center (SOC)" push where Gemini-powered agents help enterprises detect & respond to threats, bolstered by the $32B Wiz acquisition that closed in 1Q. Wiz represents Google's largest deal ever & a clear signal that security is a top strategic priority for Google. Security is a high-priority, big-budget category for every enterprise, & Google is using it as a wedge to expand wallet share & become increasingly competitive against the largest incumbents in enterprise security. Across all four themes, we believe the bar is not flashy demos but real production deployments with measurable business results. Google needs to show that customers are spending, not just experimenting.

- **Google's recent announcements reinforce the four-theme framework above. On the agentic cloud front**, Google released Gemini 3.1 Pro, w/ improved multi-step agent capabilities; Gemma 4 open model; Gemini Enterprise for Customer Experience — a prebuilt agent solution deployable in days (early adopters include Kroger, Lowe's, & Papa Johns)—and co-developed the Agent2Agent (A2A) open protocol (now 150+ supporting organizations). Furthermore, the Agent Development Kit (ADK) and a growing AI Model Garden & Agent Marketplace support Google's growing agentic AI cloud offerings. We believe agentic AI will drive recurring Vertex AI consumption & make Google harder to displace as multi-agent workflows embed into enterprise operations. **On infrastructure**, Google's 7th Gen TPU Ironwood in GA, the long-term Broadcom supply partnership extending through 2031, Anthropic securing 3.5GW of next-gen TPU compute, & Meta *potentially* signing a multi-billion-dollar deal to rent Google AI chips are all signs that Google's custom silicon & systems-level efficiency advantages can generate strong L-T ROI on infrastructure investments—and Google is leaning in to further strengthen performance & cost of infrastructure. The $4.75B Intersect Power acquisition (closed 1Q) brings 2.2 GW of solar & 2.4 GWh of battery storage in-house, enabling co-location of power with data centers to bypass grid congestion at a time when access to power is the binding constraint on AI capacity. **On security**, Google's closing of the $32B Wiz acquisition (its largest deal ever), the AI Agent Trends 2026 report highlighting Agentic Security Operations Center as a key use case (security agents expected to handle ~90% of tier-one alerts, 88% of early adopters seeing positive ROI), & its participation in Project Glasswing—a 40+ organization defensive coalition formed after Anthropic's Mythos autonomously identified thousands of high-severity vulnerabilities across major operating systems—collectively signal the strategic importance Google is placing on security as both a growth vector & a platform differentiator. We believe the Mythos moment has materially increased the urgency for AI-powered security industry-wide, & Google is increasingly well-positioned to capture wallet share with Wiz's multi-cloud platform, Gemini-powered security agents, & the Unified Security stack.

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Doug Anmuth [AC]
(1-212) 622-6571
douglas.anmuth@jpmorgan.com

J.P.Morgan

Investment Thesis, Valuation and Risks

Alphabet *(Overweight; Price Target: $395.00)*

Investment Thesis
We believe Alphabet's fundamentals are solid and the company will remain both a driver of and primary beneficiary of an increasingly digital economy & advances in Generative AI. Google remains focused on innovation, and we continue to believe there is a healthy runway across Search and YouTube ads as AI drives higher ROI & TV dollars shift online. Non-Ad businesses, incl. Cloud & Subscriptions, have significant headroom, and companies within Other Bets, notably Waymo, provide option value. We remain confident in the company's ability to innovate around Generative AI, control costs, & generate solid top-line growth.

Valuation
Our December 2026 PT of $395 is based on ~29x our '27E GAAP EPS of $13.51, which ex-cash equates to ~28x our '27E GAAP EPS ex-Other Bets of $13.95. We believe Alphabet shares should trade at a premium to the S&P 500 as Alphabet is one of the few companies in the S&P 500 with DD % revenue and EPS growth off of a very large base and a strong 32%+ GAAP Operating Income margin.

Risks to Rating and Price Target
Downside risks include: 1) Competition ramping across AI, Ads, Cloud, and for engineering/tech talent; **2)** potential for a return to heavy investment spending and margin compression; **3)** regulatory scrutiny resulting in meaningful change to operations or limiting innovation; and **4)** growth slowing more than anticipated with the next major revenue drivers, including Cloud, Hardware, and Waymo, not materializing as expected.

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Doug Anmuth [AC]
(1-212) 622-6571
douglas.anmuth@jpmorgan.com

J.P.Morgan

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Doug Anmuth [AC]
(1-212) 622-6571
douglas.anmuth@jpmorgan.com

J.P.Morgan

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Doug Anmuth [AC]
(1-212) 622-6571
douglas.anmuth@jpmorgan.com

Alphabet (GOOG, GOOG US) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Sep 28, 2004. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Date	Rating	Price ($)	Price Target ($)
26-Apr-23	OW	104.61	121
26-Jul-23	OW	122.79	150
13-Dec-23	OW	133.64	160
31-Jan-24	OW	153.05	165
26-Apr-24	OW	157.95	200
24-Jul-24	OW	183.60	208
30-Oct-24	OW	171.14	212
18-Dec-24	OW	197.12	232
05-Feb-25	OW	207.71	220
08-Apr-25	OW	149.24	180
25-Apr-25	OW	161.47	195
11-Jul-25	OW	178.70	200
24-Jul-25	OW	191.51	232
03-Sep-25	OW	211.99	260
27-Oct-25	OW	260.51	300
30-Oct-25	OW	275.17	340
12-Dec-25	OW	313.70	385
05-Feb-26	OW	333.34	395

Alphabet Inc. (GOOGL, GOOGL US) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Jul 17, 2015. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Date	Rating	Price ($)	Price Target ($)
26-Apr-23	OW	103.85	121
26-Jul-23	OW	122.21	150
13-Dec-23	OW	132.52	160
31-Jan-24	OW	151.46	165
26-Apr-24	OW	156.00	200
24-Jul-24	OW	181.79	208
30-Oct-24	OW	169.68	212
18-Dec-24	OW	195.42	232
05-Feb-25	OW	206.38	220
08-Apr-25	OW	146.75	180
25-Apr-25	OW	159.28	195
11-Jul-25	OW	177.62	200
24-Jul-25	OW	190.23	232
03-Sep-25	OW	211.35	260
27-Oct-25	OW	259.92	300
30-Oct-25	OW	274.57	340
12-Dec-25	OW	312.43	385
05-Feb-26	OW	333.04	395

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Doug Anmuth [AC]
(1-212) 622-6571
douglas.anmuth@jpmorgan.com

J.P.Morgan

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